

Buddhadeb Bhattacharya

UNSMILING BUDDHA



SUBIR HALDER

ONCE BUDDHADEB talked of taking the state to the new millennium, now he is worried about taking it to the next year. He will be known as the man who caused Nandigram.

It was a journey from the pinnacle of popularity to the depths of despair for West Bengal Chief Minister Buddhadeb Bhattacharya this year. It was only last year when he was etching his name as the man who would lead to West Bengal's resurgence, winning the state elections riding the industrialisation wave. But then, things went horribly wrong. For 2007 would always be remembered as the year when Buddhadeb caused Nandigram.

It started as early as the first week of January, when Nandigram refused to be industrialised by the proposed SEZ. It rejected Buddha's grand designs, preferring territorial strife instead. Next, on March 14, Buddha's miscalculations cost 14 lives and a lot of goodwill when he sent policemen to recapture Nandigram, held hostage by SEZ protesters. In November, the area was finally reclaimed but by then the widely-lauded chief minister was being widely condemned.

There were other faux pas too—the Rizwanur Rahman death controversy, the banishing of writer Taslima Nasreen to appease the state's communal forces—that left him on the defensive. Now, Buddha doesn't smile anymore. Once he spoke of taking West Bengal to the new millennium, now he is worried about taking it to the next year. **by Swagata Sen**

Mayawati

HEARTLAND QUEEN

In the first elections that she steered BSP without her mentor Kanshi Ram by her side, Mayawati achieved something that had eluded Uttar Pradesh's major political parties for nearly two decades—a simple majority. While her opponents still stuck to the tried-and-tested policies which had failed them in the past, Mayawati, who till then had relentlessly pandered to Dalit lobbies, embarked on a social engineering process. With Dalits accounting for a mere 21 per cent of the state population as against the 31 per cent Brahmins, she stitched together a coalition of extremes, from the oppressed to the upper castes. The improbable formula worked as BSP proved pollsters and political pundits wrong, winning 206 out of the 402 assembly seats. Never one to conceal her ambitions, she has already identified Raisina Hill as her next stop. With Mayawati you cannot rule anything out.

by Ashok K. Damodaran

WHILE HER rivals stuck to the tried-and-tested policies, Mayawati embarked on a social engineering that ultimately paid off

SPRA DAS